

Strengths

The 2024 champion enters the new season stacked with an international pedigree, underlined by as many as nine players who featured in last year's ODI World Cup. It is a new-look side in parts, with power-hitters like South Africa's Nadine de Klerk and Australian stars Grace Harris and Georgia Voll bolstering a batting group, where Richa Ghosh provides the finishing punch.

The addition of established India internationals such as Radha Yadav, Arundhati Reddy and Pooja Vastrakar gives head coach Malolan Rangarajan tactical depth across departments. England's Linsey Smith, who impressed with her attacking left-arm spin during the 50-over World Cup, could play a key role as RCB's frontline spinner in the PowerPlay.

Weaknesses

RCB's struggle to close out tight games remains a concern. Last season, it lost five straight matches, including a final-ball defeat and a Super Over loss, exposing a recurring issue under pressure. There is also an opening slot puzzle alongside Smriti Mandhana, with Harris, Voll and Dayalan Hemalatha all in contention, pointing to early experimentation before the best XI settles. Uncertainty over the fitness of Pooja Vastrakar and Shreyanka Patil adds to the unease. That has been compounded by Ellyse Perry's withdrawal for personal reasons, a significant blow, with Sayali Satghare named as her replacement.

Player to watch: Nadine de Klerk

De Klerk's ODI World Cup performances, which helped South Africa reach its maiden final, make her a key player to watch. While she offers useful overs with the ball, her primary value lies in her power-hitting. Rescue knocks against India (84 off 54) and Bangladesh (37 off 29) showcased her ability to change games late, and her finishing skills could prove decisive in turning close contests in RCB's favour.

Full squad

Smriti Mandhana, Richa Ghosh, Sayali Satghare, Shreyanka Patil, Georgia Voll, Nadine de Klerk, Radha Yadav, Lauren Bell, Linsey Smith, Prema Rawat, Arundhati Reddy, Pooja Vastrakar, Grace Harris, Gautami Naik, Prathyoosha Kumar, D. Hemalatha

Nadine de Klerk



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